

BTA ANALYTICS

Industry Intelligence Re- port

ALL TIME

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Executive Summary

The Canadian regulated cannabis market demonstrates robust engagement with its insights platform, reflecting a generally positive operational environment. Platform Advocacy NPS (Net Promoter Score for the platform), a measure of user willingness to recommend, sits strong at 80.3, underpinned by an overall Experience Quality Index (a measure of overall positive perception of the retail experience) of 81.6. The Interaction Coverage Index (a measure of engagement breadth) also shows a competitive 73.5%. However, this broad engagement does not consistently translate into frequent participation, with only 25.5% of respondents engaging weekly. The primary motivators for participation are experiential incentives such as product samples (91.5%), personal interest in topics (66.0%), and a desire to see the impact of their input (64.2%).

Despite strong platform and experience quality signals, the broader industry faces challenges in converting positive transactional experiences into robust consumer confidence and advocacy. Overall consumer advocacy, as measured by Net Promoter Score (NPS), is weak at 34.0. This gap is particularly pronounced among Budtenders, who report a critical industry NPS of 7.7, significantly below the overall average, despite showing marginally higher experience quality (84.3 vs. 81.6) and lower choice friction (68.6 vs. 73.4) in their interactions.

The market exhibits strong consumer brand loyalty, with over half (56.5%) demonstrating high loyalty, yet a substantial portion (32.0%) is open to exploring new brands. While experience quality is strong, Brand Trust Index (consumer confidence in cannabis brands) at 66.4 and Choice Friction Index (ease or difficulty in making product selections) at 56.4 remain competitive rather than strong. The low incidence of ‘Calm’ (13.6%), ‘Curious’ (6.1%), and ‘Confident’ (4.6%) purchase states suggests opportunities to empower decision-making through clearer information and enhanced guidance. The critical role of Budtenders in reducing friction and enhancing experience highlights the importance of investing in their professional development.

Spring Wave Findings

The Cannabis Retail Workforce: Engagement & Operations

The regulated cannabis market relies heavily on customer-facing roles, with a significant portion of its workforce dedicated to direct consumer interaction. Over half (54.86%) of respondents report engaging with customers 80% of the time or more, underscoring the customer-centric nature of retail operations. This deep engagement is further highlighted by the fact that completely customer-focused roles, specifically 100% interaction, constitute the single largest segment, representing 23.08% of the workforce. This suggests that retailers are primarily structuring their teams to maximize direct sales and service, which can be critical for consumer education and experience in a nuanced product category.

However, the industry also accommodates moderate levels of direct customer engagement, indicating a balance between sales and other operational responsibilities for some staff. Approximately 13.85% of respondents manage customer interaction levels between 67% and 75%. This indicates that while front-line sales are paramount, a notable segment of the workforce may be balancing customer support with inventory management, merchandising, or administrative duties, requiring a diverse skill set within the retail environment.

DATA Data: 54.86% of respondents interact with customers 80% or more (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 23.08% of respondents interact with customers 100% of the time (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 13.85% of respondents interact with customers 67%-75% of the time (Spring 2025)

For retail operators, optimizing staffing models to either specialize in direct customer interaction or effectively balance diverse responsibilities can enhance efficiency and customer service. Understanding these interaction patterns is crucial for allocating training resources and defining career paths within the retail sector.

Career Growth & Product Knowledge in Retail

Retail employers appear to encourage professional development through external events, yet a perceived lack of long-term career investment could pose retention risks for the industry. A higher percentage of respondents (16%) disagree that their employer invests in their long-term career development compared to those who agree (12%). This occurs even as 26% strongly agree their employer encourages attendance at industry events or training. This disparity suggests a potential disconnect where short-term, event-based training is offered, but a broader, strategic pathway for career progression is not clearly articulated or perceived by employees.

Cannabis brands play a pivotal role in educating budtenders, becoming a primary source of product knowledge in a rapidly evolving market. Approximately 42% of respondents rate cannabis brands as 'Very Effective' for education. This reliance on brand-provided information is particularly significant given that 18% of respondents indicate an ideal product refresh frequency of 'Every 2–3 months'. This highlights the continuous demand for up-to-date product knowledge to keep pace with innovation, placing brands in a critical position to arm the retail workforce with timely and accurate information.

DATA Data: 16% disagree vs. 12% agree on employer investment in long-term career development (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 26% strongly agree employer encourages industry event attendance (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 42% find cannabis brands 'Very Effective' as an education source (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 18% indicate ideal product refresh frequency of 'Every 2–3 months' (Spring 2025)

Retailers and brand managers should collaborate to ensure continuous, high-quality product education that transcends transactional interactions and contributes to a clear, perceived career trajectory for retail staff. This can mitigate retention challenges and foster a more knowledgeable workforce.

Staff Expertise, Recommendations, and Conversion

Staff expertise and in-person guidance are paramount for consumers in cannabis retail, often outweighing other factors like promotions or visibility. A substantial 81.9% of respondents identify staff recommendations and education as a key in-store element, surpassing the impact of promotions/price discounts (66.0%) and product visibility (57.5%). Furthermore, staff endorsement or recommendation has the biggest impact on trying new products for 35.1% of respondents, indicating that informed human interaction remains a critical driver for discovery and trust.

While staff interactions are frequent, converting these into successful recommendations that drive purchase decisions remains a competitive challenge across the industry. The Interaction Coverage

Index (a measure of engagement breadth) stands at a competitive 73.5%. However, the Recommendation Conversion Index (effectiveness of staff recommendations influencing purchase) is notably lower at 60.4%. This gap suggests that while staff are engaging with customers, the quality, relevance, or perceived trustworthiness of their recommendations may not consistently translate into consumer action, potentially due to a mismatch between staff knowledge and nuanced consumer needs or external decision factors.

Budtenders specifically demonstrate strong engagement, yet provincial recommendation conversion rates indicate varied effectiveness. Budtenders exhibit a marginally higher average Interaction Coverage Index score of 78.4% compared to the overall average. However, the Recommendation Conversion Index in Ontario is 57.5%, which is marginally below the national average of 60.4% (down 2.9 points). This suggests regional disparities in recommendation effectiveness that may be influenced by local market dynamics, product availability, or specific training needs. It is important to interpret these findings with caution, as many data points in this dataset have low sample sizes (N between 15 and 29).

DATA Data: 81.9% identify staff recommendations/education as key in-store element (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: 35.1% cite staff endorsement as biggest impact on trying new products (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Interaction Coverage Index = 73.5% (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Recommendation Conversion Index = 60.4% (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Budtenders Interaction Coverage Index = 78.4% (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Ontario Recommendation Conversion Index = 57.5% (Spring 2025)

Industry participants should prioritize enhancing the quality and relevance of staff recommendations to bridge the conversion gap, potentially through targeted training on active listening and personalized product matching. Regulators could explore supporting frameworks that ensure consistent, high-quality information delivery across provinces.

Retailer Advocacy & Brand Affinity

The market demonstrates a strong preference for familiar brands, indicating that brand loyalty and recognition are significant drivers in consumer purchasing decisions. A combined 74.2% of respondents either 'Often' repeat brand purchases (42.2%) or 'Occasionally' mix between familiar and new brands (32.0%). Furthermore, a notable 21.1% consistently stick with brands they trust. This suggests that established brand equity holds considerable sway, and consumers tend to return to known entities rather than constantly seeking novelty. Only a marginal portion (2.0%) indicates complete disengagement from brand names, reinforcing the general importance of brand identity.

While the overall industry exhibits a competitive Net Promoter Score (NPS) of 34.0 (N=106), there is a significant divergence in advocacy levels, particularly for Budtenders. A majority of overall respondents (57.5%) are promoters, with 23.6% detractors. However, Budtenders report a substantially lower NPS of 7.7 (N=52), accompanied by a higher proportion of detractors (36.5%) compared to the overall average. This critical score for Budtenders suggests that their direct, daily immersion in the industry may expose them to operational challenges or unmet expectations that temper their enthusiasm, leading to lower advocacy despite their high interaction levels. This finding for Budtenders should be interpreted with caution due to the sample size.

EARLY SIGNAL Other key industry stakeholders, such as consumers and store managers, show higher levels of advocacy, though these insights are directional due to sample sizes. Consumers (N=27) show a high promoter percentage of 74.1%, while store managers (N=27) also demonstrate strong promoter levels of 66.7%. These directional findings, which should be interpreted with caution, suggest that while Budtenders face specific challenges, other segments of the market exhibit stronger positive sentiment. In Ontario, the NPS is 22.6 (N=62), with over half of respondents (51.6%) classified as promoters, though this finding should also be interpreted with caution due to the sample size.

DATA Data: 74.2% of respondents either 'Often' repeat brand purchases (42.2%) or 'Occasionally' mix between familiar and new brands (32.0%) (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Overall NPS = 34.0 (N=106) (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Budtenders NPS = 7.7 (N=52) (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Early signal: Consumers promoter percentage = 74.1% (N=27) (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Early signal: Store managers promoter percentage = 66.7% (N=27) (Spring 2025)

DATA Data: Ontario NPS = 22.6 (N=62) (Spring 2025)

Retailers must investigate and address the specific pain points contributing to lower Budtender advocacy, as their frontline experience is critical for broader industry perception. Brands should leverage their existing loyalty while also understanding the propensity for consumers to explore, offering clear value propositions for new products.

Fall Wave Findings

Consumer Brand Loyalty & Exploration

The Canadian regulated cannabis market is characterized by a significant degree of consumer brand loyalty, with most consumers exhibiting consistent purchasing patterns. A majority of consumers, 56.5%, demonstrate high brand loyalty, primarily consisting of individuals who often have a few go-to brands (48.3%). This is complemented by a smaller segment (8.2%) that consistently sticks with brands they already know and trust. This indicates that a core segment of the market values reliability and familiarity, returning to established favourites.

While loyalty is prominent, a substantial portion of the market actively engages in brand exploration, though outright disregard for brands is rare. Nearly four in ten consumers (39.5%) exhibit mixed brand behavior, either alternating between familiar and new brands (32.0%) or occasionally selecting different options (7.5%). This openness to discovery suggests that while consumers have preferred brands, they are not entirely exclusive, creating opportunities for new entrants and diverse product lines. Notably, consumers with high brand loyalty still outnumber those who explore a mix of brands by 17.0 points. Furthermore, only a marginal segment of consumers (3.4%) rarely or never consider brand names, underscoring the general importance of brand identity across the market.

Brand Behavior Segment	Percentage
Often have a few go-to brands	48.3%
Occasionally mix familiar and new	32.0%
Consistently stick with known brands	8.2%
Occasionally select different options	7.5%
Rarely consider brand names	2.7%
Never pay attention to brand names	2.0%
Never repeat brands (prefer novelty)	0.7%

DATA Data: 56.5% of consumers demonstrate high brand loyalty (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 48.3% often have a few go-to brands (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 32.0% occasionally mix between familiar and new brands (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 8.2% consistently stick with brands they already know and trust (Fall 2025)

Brands should reinforce loyalty through consistent quality and messaging, while also strategically engaging the segment open to exploration with compelling new offerings. Retailers can support this by curating diverse selections that cater to both loyalists and adventurers.

Consumption Behavior & Purchase Planning

Consumers largely approach cannabis purchases with a moderate degree of planning, indicating a considered process rather than impulsive decision-making. A significant majority of respondents (75.8%) reported lower to moderate planning levels for their cannabis purchases (levels 1, 2, or 3), with planning level '3' being the most frequently reported at 28.8%. This suggests that consumers typically invest some thought into their purchases, potentially researching products or considering their needs before visiting a dispensary. Concurrently, the role of sales and discounts as a primary information source appears minimal, identified by only 1.5% of respondents. This indicates that promotional pricing is not a leading driver for product discovery or decision-making in this market.

The overall consumer experience in the Canadian cannabis market is strong, while brand trust and choice friction points demonstrate competitive performance. The Experience Quality Index for all respondents averages a strong 81.6 points. The Choice Friction Index (ease or difficulty in making product selections) stands at a competitive 73.4 points, and the Brand Trust Index (consumer confidence in cannabis brands) is also competitive at 66.4 points. These scores suggest that while the act of purchasing and consuming is generally positive, the process of trusting brands and making selections could be smoother. Budtenders appear to play a positive role in enhancing the experience and reducing friction for consumers, reporting a marginally higher Experience Quality Index (up 2.7 points) at 84.3 points and a marginally lower Choice Friction Index (down 4.9 points) at 68.6 points compared to the overall respondent average. This highlights their direct positive impact on the customer journey.

While overall experience quality is high, the relatively low reported incidence of 'Calm' (13.6%), 'Curious' (6.1%), and 'Confident' (4.6%) purchase states suggests an underlying opportunity to foster deeper engagement or a more assured purchasing journey. This gap could indicate a need for clearer product information to empower decision-making, opportunities to build greater consumer confidence

through education and consistent positive experiences, or an environment where consumers are still navigating product choices despite generally positive overall experiences.

DATA Data: 75.8% reported lower to moderate planning levels for cannabis purchases (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 1.5% identified sales/discounts as a primary information source (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Experience Quality Index = 81.6 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Choice Friction Index = 73.4 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Brand Trust Index = 66.4 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Budtender-assisted experience quality index = 84.3 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Budtender-assisted friction index = 68.6 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 13.6% described purchase state as 'Calm' (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 6.1% described purchase state as 'Curious' (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 4.6% described purchase state as 'Confident' (Fall 2025)

Retailers should leverage the moderate planning cycle to provide comprehensive information pre-purchase and invest in budtender training to foster 'Calm', 'Curious', and 'Confident' purchase states. Brands should focus on clear, educational messaging that builds trust beyond price.

Product Format Preferences & Brand Familiarity

The Canadian regulated cannabis market shows a significant inclination towards established brand familiarity among consumers, rather than strict single-brand loyalty or complete indifference to brands. Nearly half of all respondents (48.3%) indicated they often rely on a few specific “go-to” brands. This is further reinforced by 42.2% of respondents who generally “often” exhibit repeat brand behavior, suggesting that while consumers appreciate trusted options, their repertoire frequently extends beyond a single preferred brand.

While familiarity is common, a notable segment of the market actively seeks variety, balancing loyalty with exploration. A substantial proportion of respondents (32.0%) reported that they “occasionally” mix between familiar and new brands, indicating a significant openness to exploring different offerings. In contrast, a much smaller group (8.2%) stated they “always” stick with brands they already know and trust, suggesting that strict, unwavering brand loyalty to a single brand is less prevalent. This creates a dynamic environment where brands can both cultivate loyalty and attract new customers.

Brand name recognition holds general importance for the vast majority of consumers, underscoring the role of brand identity in purchasing decisions. Only a marginal percentage of respondents (2.0%) indicated they “never” pay attention to brand names, suggesting that brand identity is a relevant factor for almost all market participants.

DATA Data: 48.3% often rely on a few specific “go-to” brands (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 42.2% often exhibit repeat brand behavior (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 32.0% occasionally mix between familiar and new brands (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 8.2% always stick with brands they already know and trust (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 2.0% never pay attention to brand names (Fall 2025)

Brands should prioritize consistent brand messaging and product quality to become a ‘go-to’ option, while also innovating to capture the significant segment of consumers open to new, compelling offerings. Retailers can facilitate this by ensuring diverse product displays and knowledgeable staff who can guide exploration.

Trust, Sentiment, and Decision Context

Overall industry sentiment, as measured by Net Promoter Score (NPS), currently sits in the competitive range at 34.0, with a majority of respondents (57.5%) identifying as promoters. However, this sentiment is not uniform across all segments. Respondents from Ontario reported a significantly lower NPS (down 11 points) at 22.6, placing it in the critical range. **Budtenders, a key segment, exhibited a critical NPS score of 7.7, marking it as the lowest among high-confidence segments and indicating a substantial proportion of detractors (36.5%) compared to promoters (44.2%).** This suggests that while some areas of the market are performing competitively, there are significant pockets of dissatisfaction, particularly among frontline staff.

EARLY SIGNAL While specific NPS scores are not available for these smaller groups, other segments show promising directional trends. Store Managers (N=27, interpret with caution) displayed a high promoter percentage of 66.7% and a low detractor percentage of 14.8%. Similarly, consumers (N=27, interpret with caution) showed the highest promoter percentage at 74.1% and the lowest detractor percentage at 7.4%. Conversely, the 25-34 Age Group (N=27, interpret with caution) shows a more balanced, albeit concerning, distribution with 40.7% promoters and 37.0% detractors. These directional insights, to be interpreted with caution, suggest that different stakeholder groups perceive the industry differently, with consumers and store managers generally more positive.

The sentiment regarding the platform itself is notably strong, suggesting a positive experience with the association’s engagement tools. The overall Platform Advocacy NPS (Net Promoter Score for the platform) is strong at 80.3, reinforced by an overall Experience Quality Index of 81.6. Interestingly, while Budtenders reported a critical industry NPS, their experience with the platform shows a more competitive advocacy NPS of 73.1, which is slightly lower (down 7.2 points) than the overall platform average. However, Budtenders’ Experience Quality Index of 84.3 is marginally higher (up 2.7 points) than the overall average, indicating a positive experience with the quality of the platform. This divergence suggests Budtenders’ dissatisfaction may stem from broader industry issues rather than their experience with specific engagement tools.

Engagement with industry information remains high, with industry news (80.2%), research reports (70.8%), and surveys (73.6%) all considered valuable. Primary motivations for participation are personal relevance (66.0%) and community connection (60.4%), with wellness/lifestyle products preferred

rewards (58.5%). These underscore the importance of relevant content and community building. The environment for decision-making within the industry appears competitive but not without friction. The Decision Context Index (clarity or support in decision-making) stands at 58.3, and the Choice Friction Index (ease or difficulty in making product selections) is competitive at 56.4. These scores indicate areas where the clarity of options and ease of decision-making could be enhanced for consumers.

DATA Data: Overall Industry NPS = 34.0 (Fall 2025, N=106)

DATA Data: Ontario NPS = 22.6 (Fall 2025, N=62)

DATA Data: Budtenders NPS = 7.7 (Fall 2025, N=52)

DATA Data: Early signal: Store Managers promoter percentage = 66.7% (Fall 2025, N=27)

DATA Data: Early signal: Consumers promoter percentage = 74.1% (Fall 2025, N=27)

DATA Data: Overall Platform Advocacy NPS = 80.3 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Overall Experience Quality Index = 81.6 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Budtenders Platform Advocacy NPS = 73.1 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Budtenders Experience Quality Index = 84.3 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Industry news valuable to 80.2% of respondents (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Decision Context Index = 58.3 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: Choice Friction Index = 56.4 (Fall 2025)

Industry stakeholders must address the underlying reasons for the critical NPS among Budtenders and in certain regions like Ontario, as this segment's satisfaction is crucial for broader market health. Improving decision clarity and reducing choice friction are key opportunities for market growth and enhanced consumer confidence.

Community Engagement & Data Quality

The participant base demonstrates strong advocacy for the platform, which suggests the insights derived are robust and representative. The average Platform Advocacy NPS (Net Promoter Score for the platform) is strong, registering at 80.3. This positive sentiment aligns with the primary motivations for engagement, where contributing to industry research within the community (78.3%) and building professional knowledge and skills (77.4%) are key drivers. Earning points and rewards is also a substantial motivator for survey participation, cited by 85.9% of respondents.

A consistent segment of the participant community shows regular engagement, providing a steady stream of data for analysis. Weekly engagement is reported by approximately one-quarter (25.5%)

of respondents. This consistent base is also clearly motivated by specific incentives, with gift cards emerging as the most preferred reward type, selected by 78.3% of respondents.

This combination of high advocacy for the platform, intrinsic motivation for industry contribution and professional development, alongside a strong preference for tangible rewards like gift cards, points to a highly engaged and motivated participant pool. The data gathered from such a base is likely to reflect genuinely held views and experiences within the Canadian regulated cannabis market, providing a reliable signal for observation.

DATA Data: Platform Advocacy NPS = 80.3 (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 78.3% motivated by contributing to industry research (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 77.4% motivated by building professional knowledge/skills (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 85.9% motivated by earning points and rewards (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 25.5% report weekly engagement (Fall 2025)

DATA Data: 78.3% prefer gift cards as rewards (Fall 2025)

The robust engagement and advocacy for the insights platform underscore the value of continued investment in community-driven research to gather high-quality, reliable market intelligence. Industry bodies can leverage this engaged community to deepen insights into evolving market dynamics.

Implications & Looking Ahead

The Canadian regulated cannabis market is marked by strong consumer brand loyalty, with over half of consumers consistently returning to a few 'go-to' brands. While nearly four in ten consumers engage in some level of brand exploration, outright disregard for brands is rare. This suggests brands benefit from established preferences but also have an opportunity to attract consumers through differentiated offerings rather than solely relying on novelty.

Despite a strong overall consumer experience quality (Experience Quality Index 81.6) within the retail sector and consumers largely approaching purchases with moderate planning, opportunities exist to foster deeper engagement and confidence. Brand Trust Index (66.4) and Choice Friction Index (56.4) are competitive but indicate potential for improvement. The relatively low incidence of 'Calm', 'Curious', or 'Confident' purchase states, coupled with a notably weaker overall consumer advocacy Net Promoter Score of 34.0, suggests that positive transactional experiences are not consistently translating into robust brand loyalty or reduced decision-making effort. Sales and discounts, identified as a primary information source by only a marginal percentage of respondents (1.5%), appear to be a minimal driver for purchase decisions.

The positive impact of budtenders emerges as a key workforce signal for the regulated cannabis market, enhancing experience quality and reducing friction for consumers. Their demonstrated ability to enhance experience quality and reduce friction points for consumers highlights their critical role.

For **brands**, the implication is a need to build deeper trust and provide clear, empowering product information to convert existing positive experiences into strong consumer confidence and advocacy, rather than solely relying on promotional pricing. This is particularly relevant given the concurrent observation of strong brand loyalty alongside consumer openness to exploration, suggesting brands must cater to both established preferences and guided discovery. Addressing the comparatively low incidence of ‘Calm’, ‘Curious’, and ‘Confident’ purchase states represents an opportunity for brands to empower decision-making through better information, delivered partly via the retail interaction.

For **retailers**, the data strongly suggests that investing in the training and empowerment of budtenders can significantly elevate the customer journey beyond mere transaction. While overall experience quality is strong, the relatively weak consumer advocacy signals a gap that an informed and supportive workforce can bridge, transforming positive encounters into deeper engagement and loyalty. Budtenders are key to converting generally positive experiences into more assured purchasing journeys and building trust that translates into advocacy.

From a **policy** perspective, recognizing the substantial influence of budtenders on consumer experience and information acquisition could lead to considerations around supporting professional development, education standards, or clear communication guidelines for this retail workforce. Policies that encourage transparent and empowering product information could further support budtenders in fostering more confident and informed consumer decisions, thereby strengthening the overall market environment.

Methodology & Data Quality

 SECTION NOT GENERATED — Methodology and data quality information for both the Spring and Fall waves were not provided in the original analytics pipeline output.

Report Metadata

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